‘post-truth’ society in which fact and fiction occupy the same space, leaving it entirely up to the reader to sort out the one from the other. The populist anti-intellectualism with which the Brexiters won the argument in Britain’s recent national referendum on the European Union, with a leading politician boasting that ‘People in this country have had enough of experts’, and the way in which a multi-millionaire fantasist seemingly incapable of separating truth from lies has been elected President of the United States, strongly suggests that the well-known maxim[33] ‘Everyone is entitled to their own opinions, but not to their own facts’ no longer applies.

Yet even in the face of these massive failures of reasoned democracy, the bottom line remains, which is that society is invariably diminished when falsehood goes unchallenged. Both in Britain and in the United States of America we the people are now having to face the consequences of failing to do just that. I hope – and believe – that India can do better.

The Republic of India is a truly astonishing experiment in democracy on the grand scale. Consider these bare statistics: the European Union, from which the British people are now set on divorcing themselves, is made up of twenty-eight member states with a total population of just over 500 million speaking twenty-four official languages and some fifty minority and ‘immigrant’ languages. India is made up of twenty-nine states and seven union territories with a total population of over 1.3 billion, made up of over 2000 ethnic groups speaking 122 major languages and more than 1600 minority languages. Yet it holds together. What an achievement!

In all my travels across India, now extending over seventy-seven years, I have never once been assaulted, or robbed or even been verbally abused. Official indifference, yes, when it comes to banks and getting permits, but in